MOREH NEVUCHIM

How to Read the Moreh: Meshalim, Method & Mission

Given Tuesday 5 May 2026 · Rambam's Intro to Moreh Nevuchim, Part 3

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** The Rambam's Introduction (continuing toward conclusion) **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Recap: The Rambam's Introduction So Far

Shiur 1 (Pre-Pesach) — Background

- Biography of the Rambam and the historical context of the Moreh

Shiur 2 — Why Rambam Wrote the Book

- Letter to his student Rabbi Yosef
- Purpose: to explain veiled imagery, multi-meaning terms, and metaphors in Tanakh
- Audience: those educated in both Torah and philosophy who are perplexed
- Why he can't explain everything exhaustively (Ma'aseh Bereishit and Ma'aseh Merkavah belong to the realm of *rashei perakim* only)
- The lightning analogy — most prophets have flashes; the most we can hope for is occasional shine

Shiur 3 — Why Bereishit and the Importance of Meshalim

- Bereishit is natural science — the first rung of the ladder up to metaphysics → understanding Hashem → proper observance of mitzvot
- Even Bereishit is multi-layered (simple meaning for children, deeper meanings for the developed)
- The abandoned projects on prophecy and on derashot
- Two beautiful meshalim:

- **The candle and the diamond** — a worthless candle can light up priceless treasures
- **Golden apples in silver settings** — the surface has value, but the depth is greater (silver eyelets that allow the gold beneath to peek through)

This Evening's Shiur

We are completing the introduction this evening (with possibly some spillover into next week). Three major sections:

1. **Two types of meshalim in Tanakh** — when every word matters vs. when only the general idea matters
2. **The Rambam's advice to the reader** — including his two oaths and his most powerful personal statement
3. **The first four (of seven) reasons books contain contradictions** — laying the groundwork for understanding apparent contradictions in the Moreh itself

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PART 1 — The Two Types of Meshalim

דע שיש שתי דרכים במשלי הנבואה

The Rambam tells us this is *crucial* to understand. There are **two types of meshalim** in Tanakh:

Type A — Every Word Matters

Each individual word in the mashal carries its own meaning and contributes a specific element to the deeper truth.

Type B — The General Concept Matters

The mashal is verbose. Many words are present, but not every word carries its own deeper meaning. The extra words serve one of two purposes:

- **To make the mashal more attractive** and complete as a story
- **To deliberately conceal the deeper meaning** — paradoxically, more words can hide more effectively

Counter-intuitively, sometimes more verbiage is used **to obscure**, not to clarify. The deeper truth is buried inside an elaborate narrative.

Example of Type A — Yaakov's Ladder

והנה סולם מצב ארצה וראשו מגיע השמימה והנה מלאכי אלהים עלים וירדים בו והנה ה' נצב עליו

The Rambam identifies **seven distinct elements**, each of which adds meaning to the nimshal:

#	Element	Word(s)
1	The ladder itself	סולם
2	Set on the earth	מצב ארצה
3	Reaching to heaven	ראשו מגיע השמימה
4	Angels	מלאכי אלהים
5	Going up	עלים
6	Going down	יורדים
7	Hashem standing above	ה' נצב עליו

One Reading of the Seven (Following the Ramchal and Others)

The Rambam doesn't spell out what the seven correspond to, but the meforshim suggest:

- **All reality is composed of chomer and tzura** (matter and form, physical and spiritual)
- The ladder is the **bridge** connecting the two realms
- **Artza (earth)** = the chomer, the physical, the material
- **Hashamayma (heavens)** = the spiritual realm
- *Why "up"?* Hashem is no more "up" than down. But humans naturally give prominence to elevated things — a tall person commands more presence — so when conveying spiritual elevation, the language of "up" becomes natural (אשא עיני אל ההרים)
- **Malachei Elohim** = the word *malach* comes from לך (to go) — these are messengers, agents of change, reactions and effects
- **Olim** (going up) = our human actions emanating change upward — every mitzvah, every aveirah, sends consequences up. This is a major theme in the Ramchal and Nefesh HaChaim.
- **Yordim** (going down) = celestial forces emanating change downward into our physical world
- **Hashem nitzav alav** = Hashem oversees and supervises the entire system

Each word is a discrete piece of metaphysical instruction. Every word counts.

Layers of the Same Mashal

Notice how this same mashal works at multiple depths:

- **Children's level:** Yaakov dreamed of a ladder with angels going up and down
- **Rashi's level:** the angels of chutz la'aretz were leaving and the angels of Eretz Yisrael were arriving as Yaakov crossed the border
- **Rambam's / philosophical level:** the seven-element map of how chomer and tzura interact through human action and divine emanation

This is exactly what the Rambam established in earlier shiurim — multi-level meaning.

Example of Type B — The Seductress in Mishlei (Chapter 7)

כי בחלון ביתי בעד אשנבי נשקפתי ואראה בפתאים אבינה בבנים נער חסר לב...

A long, vivid, deliberately verbose passage:

- The narrator looks out his window and sees a young, foolish boy walking through the streets at twilight
- A woman approaches him, dressed as a harlot, "rebellious" and never at home — sometimes in the squares, sometimes lurking at corners
- She grabs him, kisses him, speaks brazenly: *"Today I have brought sacrifices and fulfilled my vows..."*
- She invites him: *"My bed is decked with Egyptian linens, perfumed with myrrh, aloes, and cinnamon — let us drink our fill of love until morning..."*
- Her closing argument: *"My husband is not at home — he has gone on a long journey, taking a purse of money. He won't return until the full moon."*
- The young man is seduced and led to ruin

The Single Point of the Whole Mashal

העולה מקצת הדברים האלו היא האזהרה מפני המשכות אחרי תענוגות הגוף ותאוותיו

Don't be drawn after physical desires. That's the entire point. One unified message — an extended warning against following the seductive pull of materialism.

Why an Eshet Ish AND a Zonah?

Why does Shlomo describe the seductress as both a **harlot** AND a **married woman**? Surely one would suffice?

The answer goes to the heart of chomer and tzura:

- **Chomer (matter)** is traditionally represented by the **woman** — she receives form, holds it, develops it
- **Tzura (form)** is represented by the **man** — he provides the formative principle
- *Example:* conception. The man contributes the formative tzura in moments. The woman holds, develops, and gives physical reality to that form over nine months. Without her chomer, the tzura is just theoretical.

So: **the seductress as eshet ish** = matter that already belongs to another form. When you chase physical desire (the eshet ish-zonah), you are taking matter that is bound to a different form, claiming it for yourself improperly. It's not just any indulgence — it's appropriation of matter that has another rightful relationship.

Eshet Chayil at the End of Mishlei

The end of the book reverses this image — the **Eshet Chayil**, the woman of valor, is matter rightly aligned with its proper form. She develops her home and her husband. This is the redemptive counter-image to the seductress of chapter 7.

The Single Lesson

כלומר האדם לא ימשך אחר בהמיותו בלבד

Don't follow your purely animal nature. Why? Because **your physical/material aspect is identical to that of any animal.** If you live only by physical desires, there is no differentiation between you and a beast.

The Rambam's Critical Warning

Now that we know this is a Type B mashal, **don't ask** why the verses say:

- "Sacrifices today, vows fulfilled" — *why specifically that?*
- "Egyptian linens" — *why Egyptian and not Persian?*
- "My husband is far away with a money purse" — *why mention the money?*

These are part of the **literary scaffolding** — designed to depict adulterous behavior vividly. They're not coded with deeper meaning.

שקצת המצבים שהזכיר הם מצב ממין מצב הנואפים

Some of the details are simply how adulterers actually behave and speak — narrative realism, not encrypted instruction.

The Rambam's Sharpest Critique of Bad Methodology

אך המבולבלים שמוחם הזדהם בהשקפות מוטעות... הם יסלדו מפרקים רבים ממנו

If you press for hidden meaning where none was intended, **two errors result**:

Error 1 — You Lose the Main Point

Investigating "why Egyptian linens?" instead of "what is this mashal warning against?" → you miss the entire purpose.

Error 2 — You Manufacture Meaning That Was Never There

או שיחייב אותך לפרש דברים שאין להם פירוש ושלא נולדו לפירוש

You force interpretations onto material that was never written to bear them.

ומחייבת זאת תביא אותך אל כגון ההזיה העצומה הזאת שרוב כיתות העולם בזמננו הזו אותם

The Rambam sees this **happening in his own time** — and it's eerily applicable to ours:

- Someone has a nice idea
- Finds a pasuk that *almost* fits
- Stuffs the idea into the verse — through gematria, through wordplay, through forced reading
- Declares: "This is what the Torah meant!"
- The Rambam's verdict: this is **מגלה פנים בתורה שלא כהלכה** — explaining Torah as it was never meant to be explained

This is a genuine *chiddush* of the Rambam: **not every word in every mashal is loaded with meaning.** Some words are dressing. The skill of the reader is knowing which is which.

How to Read Meshalim Correctly

אלא לעולם תהא כוונתך ברוב המשלים לדעת הכללות שהם כיוונו להם

For most meshalim, **focus on the general meaning** — what is this trying to teach overall?

For some, the Rambam says he won't even explicitly identify the nimshal:

משום שכאשר תדע שזה משל יתברר לך מיד לאיזה דבר הוא משל

Once you know it's a mashal, you can usually figure out the point yourself. Just identifying something as a mashal is, the Rambam says, like *removing a screen between vision and the visible* — it's enough.

Summary of Part 1

Two Types of Meshalim	
Type A — every word matters	Yaakov's ladder (7 distinct elements)
Type B — general idea matters	The seductress in Mishlei 7 (one unified warning against materialism)

The reader's job: identify which type you're dealing with, and don't manufacture meaning where none was intended.

PART 2 — The Rambam's Advice to the Reader

Advice 1 — Read the Whole Book Carefully and Compare Chapters

אם תרצה להשיג את כל מה שכללתי בו... השווה פרקיו זה עם זה

Don't just understand the general idea of any single chapter. Pay attention to:

- **Every term** the Rambam uses
- **Every phrase** — even if it seems incidental to the chapter's main topic
- **The order of chapters** — even if you think a topic belongs elsewhere, the Rambam placed it where he did for a reason
- **Constant cross-reference** — comparing chapters reveals layers a single reading misses

שבחיבור הזה הדברים לא באו כפי שנזדמן אלא בדקדוק גדול ובדיוק רב

The book is constructed with extreme precision. Nothing is accidental.

אל תקרא אותו אחר דמיונך ושיבושך

Don't read it through your preconceived notions. That damages both the author and the reader.

Advice 2 — The Two Oaths

משביע אני בשם יתעלה כל מי שקרא חיבור זה

The Rambam imposes **two oaths** on every reader.

Oath 1 — Don't Teach What's Genuinely Original Here

לא יפרש ממני אפילו מילה אחת ולא יבאר לאחרים ממני אלא מה שהוא מבואר ומפורש בדברי מי שקדם לי

Only repeat to others what is **already explicit** in established Torah and earlier Chachamim. Don't repeat the Rambam's own *chiddushim* to people who aren't ready.

Oath 2 — Don't Rush to Accuse

ולא יחפוץ לטעון נגדי

Don't be quick to attack. The Rambam writes:

- *Maybe what you understood from my words is not what I meant*
- *You will harm me when I was trying to help you*
- *That would be repaying good with evil*

If you find something that **helps you** — say a hearty thanks to Hashem. If you find **nothing useful** — treat it as if the book hadn't been written. Move on. If you find something that seems **wrong or problematic** — give the benefit of the doubt and look for an alternative reading, **even a forced one**.

יפרשנו שלא כפשוטו אפילו בפירוש דחוק ביותר וידינו לכף זכות

This obligation is greater for a Talmid Chacham than for the average person:

- *Average person:* if it's 50/50 whether they did wrong, you're obligated to give benefit of the doubt

- *Talmid Chacham:* even if 90% of the evidence is against them, you should still give benefit of the doubt

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The Problem with Oath 1

Oath 1 is genuinely difficult — taken literally, it would mean we shouldn't be having this shiur. So how do we approach it?

Possible Resolutions (Rav Kook and others discuss this)

1. **The Rambam himself softens it later** — he is going to say in this very introduction that עת לעשות לה' הפרו תורתך — sometimes the urgent need overrides ordinary protocols of esoteric concealment
2. **Everyone before us has interpreted the Moreh** — Abarbanel, Shem Tov, Crescas, and many others wrote commentaries. Either they all violated the oath, or the oath has a more nuanced reading.
3. **Halachically uncertain** whether you can publish a book and then bind readers by oath retroactively
4. **The deeper point of Oath 1** — the Rambam is making a strong rhetorical statement: *don't misuse this book.* Don't bring it to people for whom emunah peshutah is healthier. There are people who are better served by simple faith than by the kinds of questions and answers in the Moreh.

The Practical Outflow

- For some people, **simple faith is genuinely better**
- Bereishit at the simple level satisfies their need
- For perplexed people, the Moreh's depth is essential
- Match the audience to the level

Advice 3 — Who Will Benefit From This Book

The Rambam identifies three categories of reader:

Beginners

יודע אני שכל מתחיל מבני אדם שלא ישיג דבר מן העיון יפסיד

Even beginners will gain *something* — though not everything.

(Note: this is striking, because the Rambam emphasized earlier that the book is for those already trained in both philosophy and Torah. Yet he acknowledges that even simple readers will pick up some benefit.)

The Wise and Perplexed

השלם מבני אדם מאמין בתורה נבוך כמו שציינתי יפיק תועלת בכל פרקיו

For those who are knowledgeable in Torah AND philosophically trained AND perplexed by the apparent tension — every chapter will be useful, and the experience will be deeply joyful.

The Confused but Self-Confident

אך המבולבלים שמוחם הזדהם בהשקפות מוטעות

This is the most damning category — those whose minds are polluted with mistaken views, who *think* they are wise and philosophical but actually know nothing of philosophy or science. **Better that they not touch this book.**

- They will recoil from many chapters
- They won't understand the methodology
- And worst — if they probe deep enough, they'll discover their own shallowness, which they will resent

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The Rambam's Most Powerful Personal Statement

אני האיש כשנלחץ הדבר וצר המקום ולא מצאתי תחבולה ללמד האמת המוכחת אלא בדרך שתאות לאיש מעלה אחד ותאות להקניט אלפים בורים — אעדיף לאומרה לאותו אחד...

"I am the man who, when faced with an unavoidable need to teach a demonstrated truth, and finding no way to do so except in a manner that satisfies one elevated person while displeasing ten thousand ignoramuses — I will say it for that one elevated person, and I will not pay heed to the criticisms of the multitude."

ואשאף לחלץ אותו איש מעלה בודד ממה שנקלע אליו ואנחהו ממבוכתו עד שיגיע שם אל השלמות ויירגע

"I will strive to extract that one elevated person from his confusion, to lead him from his perplexity until he arrives at completeness and finds rest."

This is the **mission statement of the entire Moreh** in one paragraph: better to truly help one perplexed person than to comfortably please ten thousand who don't actually want truth.

If only our leaders in every walk of life would think this way — what a different world we would live in.

Summary of Part 2 — The Advice

#	Advice
1	Read carefully — every term, every phrase, every chapter sequence is intentional
2 (Oath 1)	Don't pass on the Rambam's own chiddushim to those not ready
2 (Oath 2)	Don't rush to attack — give benefit of the doubt, find alternative readings if needed
3	The book benefits beginners (some), the wise-and-perplexed (greatly), but harms the confused-and-arrogant
4	The mission: rescue one perplexed person rather than comfort ten thousand confused ones

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PART 3 — The Seven Reasons for Contradictions in Books

Why This Final Introduction?

The Rambam knows readers will encounter what *appear* to be contradictions in the Moreh. Rather than let readers conclude he was sloppy or self-contradictory, he prepares them in advance:

- Books in general can contain contradictions for **seven distinct reasons**
- He will list all seven
- Then he will tell us **which reasons apply to the Moreh** (it turns out, only #5 and #7)

So if you find an apparent contradiction in the Moreh, you'll know to interpret it through reasons 5 or 7 — not the others.

Reason 1 — Compilation Without Attribution

שמחבר אסף אמירות של אנשים בעלי דעות שונות והשמיט שם האומר

The author collected statements from different people with conflicting views — but didn't say who said what.

Result: the book contains contradictions because page 5 cites Rabbi A and page 65 cites Rabbi B, but neither attribution is preserved.

Classic example: the Mishna. We know each statement reflects a different opinion, but to a casual reader unfamiliar with the rabbis' positions, the contradictions seem unaccountable.

One of the rabbanim used to say: keeping this principle in mind when learning Shulchan Aruch resolves a great many of your questions.

Reason 2 — The Author Changed His Mind

כאשר בעל הספר הזה היתה דעה מסוימת ולאחר מכן חזר בו

The author held one view when he wrote one section, and a different view when he wrote a later section. He never went back and revised the earlier material.

The Rambam himself did this:

- The Cambridge Genizah preserves manuscripts of the **Peirush HaMishnayot** that he wrote in his early 20s
- We can see his own marginal corrections from later in life
- But not every author has time to retract — and many contradictions in any author's body of work come down to early-career vs. late-career thought

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Reason 3 — One Statement Has a Deeper Meaning

כאשר לא כל הדברים האלו כחיצוניותם אלא חלקם כחיצוניותם וחלקם משל שיש לו תוך

Two statements appear to contradict, but one (or both) has a deeper meaning. They only seem contradictory at the surface level.

Example A — Seeing Hashem

- **Moshe:** לא יראני האדם וחי — *no human can see Me and live* (Shemot)
- **Yeshayahu:** וארא את ה' יושב על כסא רם ונשא — *I saw Hashem sitting on a throne, high and exalted* (Yeshayah 6)

At surface level: direct contradiction. **Resolution:** clearly one or both is not literal — Yeshayahu's "vision" is a prophetic experience, not physical sight.

Example B — Hashem as a Man?

- **Beshalach:** ה' איש מלחמה ה' שמו — *Hashem is a man of war*
- **Balak:** לא איש אל ויכזב — *God is not a man*

Resolution: "Man" in Beshalach is metaphorical (a warrior); the literal sense is denied in Balak. One is mashal, the other is straight statement.

Reason 4 — A Hidden Caveat / Qualification

שיש תנאי שאינו מפורש במקומו

Two statements look contradictory because there's an unstated condition or context that distinguishes them.

Example — Answering a Fool

The Gemara cites two verses from Shlomo:

אל תען כסיל כאיולתו — *do not answer a fool according to his folly*
ענה כסיל כאיולתו — *answer a fool according to his folly*

Resolution from the Gemara (Shabbat):

הא בדברי תורה — when it concerns Torah matters, answer (you can't let foolish ideas about Torah pass)
הא במילי דעלמא — when it concerns mundane matters, ignore

The contradiction dissolves once the unstated condition is supplied.

Reasons 5, 6, 7 — Coming Next Week

These are more complex and require further development. We'll cover them next time, then see the Rambam's examples for each, and finally see his identification of which reasons apply to the Moreh itself (only #5 and #7).

Where We Stand

We have completed:

- The two types of meshalim (Part 1)
- The advice to the reader (Part 2)
- Reasons 1–4 for contradictions in books (Part 3, partial)

We have remaining:

- Reasons 5, 6, 7
- Examples of each
- The Rambam's identification of which apply to the Moreh
- **And then** — finally — the actual Chapter 1 of the Moreh itself

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Coming Up Next

- **Next class (first half):** Reasons 5, 6, 7 for contradictions, examples, and the Rambam's classification of the Moreh's contradictions
- **Following that: Chapter 1 of the Moreh itself** — the actual discussion of specific terms in Tanakh begins. We start unpacking the multi-meaning words and metaphors that this entire introduction has been preparing us to read.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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